war and repatriates who were by and large proPakistani. The division, to some extent, was further crystallised by the fact that the freedom fighters had obtained certain advantages and the repatriates some disadvantages by the creation of Bangladesh. However, the individual views and ambitions of senior officers blurred the line to some extent. The personal loyalties of units and formations also confused the situation. The influence of political parties like the JSD and Islamabad factions like the ex-Muslim Leaguers and their territorial and regional loyalties added another factor to the equation.

The R&AW felt, however, that the influence of a re-emphasised Islamic identity would be as strong in the Bangladeshi armed forces as it was in the rest of the country. The spies believed that in the wake of a tussle between senior officers, the loyalties of the armed forces could be influenced by some political parties. It was very much clear that of all the contenders for power amongst the senior armed forces officers, Ziaur Rahman wielded the greatest influence with the largest number of followers and had become effective enough to dampen the indiscipline instigated by political parties.

Indian spies who worked tirelessly to restore normalcy in Bangladeshi recalled the torments of waiting out a dark and cold night for a warm dawn. Since it was impossible to form a government in exile, given Bangladesh's political situation, the R&AW officers began recruiting people close to Ziaur Rahman. The operation was purely political. The Indian interest was limited to restoring democratic rule in its neighbouring country. Zia was making several amendments to the Bangladeshi constitution to allow the army to rule with an iron hand and Indian spies were convinced that such arrangements couldn't last forever. Abu Sadat Mohammad Sayem, the former